

Keeping the Tongue and Heart Alive With the Remembrance of Allah

A polished American English article based on the Urdu Islahi Majlis led by Mufti Husain Ahmad

Translated and arranged for clear reading

Allah Most High commands the believers:

“O you who believe, remember Allah with much remembrance, and glorify Him morning and evening.”

The remembrance of Allah (*dhikr Allāh*) is not limited to one form. Reciting the Qur'an is remembrance. Saying *subhān Allāh wa-bi-ḥamdihī* is remembrance. Seeking forgiveness (*istighfār*) is remembrance. Sending blessings upon the Prophet (*durūd sharīf*) is remembrance. Any word or action that turns the servant toward Allah is part of remembrance.

A Companion once came to the Messenger of Allah *ṣallā Allāhu 'alayhi wa-sallam* and asked for a short piece of advice. The Prophet *ṣallā Allāhu 'alayhi wa-sallam* told him to keep his tongue moist with the remembrance of Allah. This means a believer should make remembrance a habit: while walking, entering the masjid, leaving the home, eating, working, or resting. The tongue should remain connected to Allah through the supplications (*ad'iyah*), praises, and words taught by the Sunnah.

Many people ask Allah for a good ending. They ask that their death come upon faith (*īmān*). But a person's ending is usually connected to the way he lived. A well-known spiritual principle says: “As you live, so shall you die.” If a person lives with the remembrance of Allah, then by Allah's mercy, it is hoped that this remembrance will also be present at the time of death.

In this world, we still have choice. We can choose how we spend our days. We can choose what we say, what we watch, what we eat, and how we worship. At death, and in the Hereafter, those choices will no longer be in our hands. Crossing the Bridge (*ṣirāṭ*) will not be a time to choose a new path. That choice is given now. So the wise person uses this life to prepare for the next.

Some people want to live like those who are heedless of Allah, but they want to die like the noble Companions (*ṣaḥābah*) *raḍiya Allāhu 'anhum*. This is not how spiritual life works. If we want a blessed death, we must try to live a blessed life.

Religion is not as hard as we sometimes imagine. Allah has made the path clear. A person does not need to leave normal life. He eats, works, rests, spends time with family, and fulfills his needs. But he tries to do these things according to the prophetic way (*sunnah*). Eating can become worship. Entering and leaving places can become worship. Ordinary life becomes filled with light when it follows the way of the Prophet *ṣallā Allāhu 'alayhi wa-sallam*.

Two Great Foundations: God-Consciousness and Remembrance

The Qur'an repeatedly emphasizes two great matters. The first is God-consciousness (*taqwā*). The second is the remembrance of Allah (*dhikr Allāh*).

God-consciousness (*taqwā*) includes two meanings: fearing Allah and protecting oneself from sin. These two meanings are connected. When a person has reverent fear (*khashyah*) of Allah, it becomes easier to stay away from disobedience. This fear is not like fear of a wild animal or fear of harm from creation. It is reverent awe, a fear joined with love, respect, and recognition of Allah's greatness.

The more this awe enters the heart, the more a person is protected from sin. This is why the Prophet *ṣallā Allāhu 'alayhi wa-sallam* taught us to ask Allah for enough awe of Him to keep us away from His disobedience.

The second great foundation is remembrance. Many acts of worship are commanded in the Qur'an, but remembrance has a special command of abundance: remember Allah much. Prayer, fasting, charity, and other acts are all great, but the Qur'an especially tells us to make remembrance frequent and constant.

The Three Levels of Remembrance

Remembrance has levels.

The first level is remembrance by the tongue (*dhikr lisānī*). This is when a person recites words of remembrance, even if the heart is not fully focused. He may say *lā ilāha illā Allāh*, seek forgiveness, send blessings upon the Prophet *ṣallā Allāhu 'alayhi wa-sallam*, or recite from the Qur'an. This level is still valuable. It has reward and blessing.

A person should not say, "My heart is not focused, so I will stop." No. The first level is still better than leaving remembrance altogether. A person must begin somewhere. One cannot reach the second floor without first stepping onto the first.

The second level is remembrance with the tongue and the heart. This means a person says the words while also paying attention to Allah. His mind and heart are present. The more focus he has, the greater the effect of that remembrance.

This is why there is such a difference between our worship and the worship of the Companions *raḍiya Allāhu 'anhum*. The outer actions may look similar, but their hearts were deeply present. Worship has an outward form and an inward reality. The outward form is what the body and tongue do. The inward reality is attention, humility, love, and awe.

The third level is deeper still. A person remembers Allah with the tongue, remembers Him with the heart, and also looks at what Allah wants from him at that moment. He asks, "What is my duty right now according to the sacred law (*sharī'ah*)?"

Remembrance does not only mean sitting in a corner and repeating words. Sometimes the remembrance of Allah is to serve one's parents, fulfill a responsibility, earn lawful income, teach, help, or remain patient. A Companion once wanted to go out for struggle in Allah's path. The Prophet *ṣallā Allāhu 'alayhi wa-sallam* asked him about his parents. When it became clear that they needed him, the Prophet *ṣallā Allāhu 'alayhi wa-sallam* directed him to serve them. That was his path of struggle at that time.

So the servant must ask: "What is Allah asking from me now?" Sometimes a person wants to do an act that seems very virtuous, but another duty is more urgent. True remembrance includes living according to Allah's command in the present moment.

Why the Heart Loses Focus

A person may say, "When I begin remembrance, I feel focused. But after a little while, my mind wanders. In prayer, I cannot keep my heart present. In Qur'an recitation, my thoughts go everywhere."

The Qur'an explains the path to focus. Allah describes the successful believers as those who have humility and concentration in prayer (*khushū`*) and those who turn away from useless things (*laghw*). These two qualities are connected. If a person does not avoid useless and harmful things outside prayer, it becomes very hard to have focus inside prayer.

Useless things (*laghw*) include speech and actions that bring no real benefit. Worse than useless things are sins (*ma`āṣī*). Sin darkens the heart. When the heart is dark, worship loses its sweetness. A person may still say the words of supplication (*du`ā`*), but the heart feels distant.

Sometimes the obstacle is unlawful or doubtful food. If something doubtful or unlawful enters a person's body, it can affect worship. Sometimes the obstacle is a visible sin, such as backbiting, hurting others, or looking at what is unlawful. Sometimes the obstacle is an inward sin, hidden inside the heart.

Among the most dangerous inward sins is arrogance (*kibr*).

The Danger of Arrogance

The Prophet *ṣallā Allāhu `alayhi wa-sallam* taught that a person who has even a small amount of arrogance in the heart cannot enter Paradise until that arrogance is purified. Arrogance is not always visible. A person may look religious outwardly, but inside he may still carry pride.

The Prophet *ṣallā Allāhu `alayhi wa-sallam* explained the signs of arrogance. The first is rejecting the truth (*baṭar al-ḥaqq*). The second is looking down on people (*ghamṭ al-nās*).

Rejecting the truth means that when someone corrects us, we become angry. We say, "Who is he to tell me?" or "Why did he say that to me?" Instead of asking whether the correction is true, the ego becomes defensive.

But every child of Ādam makes mistakes. The Prophet *ṣallā Allāhu `alayhi wa-sallam* told us this. The real issue is not whether we make mistakes. The issue is whether we accept correction when Allah sends someone to show us our mistake.

A person who points out a real fault has done us a favor, even if he did not say it perfectly. If something is on a person's face and nobody tells him, he walks around unaware. A mirror shows him the mark. The mirror is doing him a favor. In the same way, someone who shows us a fault can become a means of mercy from Allah.

Shaykh al-Ḥadīth Mawlānā Zakariyyā *nawwara Allāhu marqadah* was once asked about the sign that humility (*tawāḍu`*) is entering a person. He said, in meaning, that when someone criticizes you, points out a mistake, or mentions a fault, you take it well, listen carefully, and do not become angry. This is a sign that humility is developing.

Arrogance is a disease that grows if it is not treated. When a person refuses the truth again and again, argues without sincerity, and insists on defending himself, Allah may deprive him after giving him guidance. Religious history contains many lessons of people who were guided, but argumentation and pride led them away.

Arrogance is called the mother of spiritual diseases. Many other sins grow from it: jealousy, hatred, arguments, rivalry, love of status, and love of fame. When humility enters the heart, many conflicts disappear.

Looking at Allah, Not Only at People

The friends of Allah (*awliyā`*) trained their hearts to see Allah behind events. They did not ignore outward causes, but their main attention was on Allah.

It is related that Ḥaḍrat Bāyazīd Baṣṭāmī *rahmatullāhi ‘alayh* was once walking in clean clothes, perhaps for Jumu‘ah or another important occasion. Someone threw garbage from above, and it fell on him. Most people would become angry, and outwardly the person who threw it had done wrong. But the gaze of the pious is different. They look toward Allah.

He said, in meaning, “O Allah, it is Your favor that You did not rain fire upon me. You only allowed garbage to fall on me.”

This is not an ordinary way of thinking. It comes when arrogance leaves the heart and inner purity (*qalb salīm*) begins to develop. The person no longer sees only people and causes. He sees that everything happens by Allah’s permission. This does not mean wrong becomes right, but it means the servant learns humility, patience, and self-knowledge.

The Deep Understanding of the Companions

The Companions *raḍiya Allāhu ‘anhum* had a special ability to take a small prophetic instruction and live by it fully. We often need many examples and stories before we understand. They heard one instruction and made it part of their lives.

Some Companions gave a pledge to the Prophet *ṣallā Allāhu ‘alayhi wa-sallam* that they would not ask people for anything. We might understand this only as not asking for money. But their understanding was deeper. If one of them was riding a camel and dropped something, he would not ask a person standing nearby to pick it up. He would make the camel sit, climb down, pick it up himself, and then climb back on.

For them, the prophetic word was enough. They did not look for loopholes. They tried to fulfill the command with sincerity.

This is the spirit a believer should seek: not merely outward practice, but inward surrender.

The Prophet’s Humility

The opposite of arrogance is humility (*tawāḍu’*). The greatest example of humility is the Messenger of Allah *ṣallā Allāhu ‘alayhi wa-sallam*. Allah gave him the highest rank, yet he lived with complete simplicity.

He did not prefer a raised seat for himself. He sat among the Companions like one of them. Sometimes visitors from outside Madinah would come and not recognize him. They would ask, “Which of you is Muḥammad?” They did not know the proper manners, but this happened because the Prophet *ṣallā Allāhu ‘alayhi wa-sallam* did not sit like a king.

Later, when the gathering grew and people needed to see him clearly, a slightly raised place was arranged. This was not for pride. It was for the ease of others. This is an important difference. Sometimes a chair, platform, or microphone is used not to show status, but so people can hear and see without difficulty.

The Prophet’s humility appeared in public gatherings, in walking with the Companions, and in his home life. Many complaints today arise in family life because people forget prophetic character. Prayer is essential, but character (*akhlāq*) is also central. If the heart is filled with pride, harshness, and selfishness, then it is not a sound heart (*qalb salīm*). In the Hereafter, salvation requires coming to Allah with a sound heart.

The Phone and Modern Uselessness

A believer must avoid both sins and useless distractions. In our time, one of the greatest sources of useless distraction is the phone. A person says, “I do not have time to read Qur’an.” But then he checks a few messages, scrolls a little, and loses one or two hours.

How much Qur’an could have been recited in that time? How many prayers upon the Prophet *ṣallā Allāhu ‘alayhi wa-sallam*? How much seeking forgiveness (*istighfār*)?

The truth is that people make time for what they value. If something is important, they find time for it. So each person should build a daily routine and decide that certain acts must be part of life.

A Simple Daily Program

A believer should try to include five things in daily life.

First, there should be some Qur’an recitation (*tilāwah*) every day. This includes regular recitation from the muṣḥaf and also the special sūrahs and recitations taught in the Sunnah. A person may recite Sūrat al-Mulk at night, Sūrat al-Kahf on Friday, Sūrat Yāsīn, Sūrat al-Wāqī‘ah, or other portions according to ability. Not everyone can begin with a large amount. Start small, but be consistent.

The Qur’an is one of the greatest gifts Allah has given us. Our connection with it should include both reciting it and trying to understand it. If there are lessons or study circles in the masjid, a person should benefit from them.

Second, there should be some optional prayers (*nawāfil*). A person may pray after Maghrib, after ‘Ishā’, or at another suitable time. Obligatory prayers are required, and leaving them is sinful. But optional worship shows love. It is like the difference between a child who obeys only out of fear of punishment and one who serves out of love. The servant should say, “Allah has given me so many blessings. Let me do something extra for His sake.”

Third, a person should keep learning the prophetic practices (*sunan*) and act upon them. Small actions can carry great reward when done according to the Sunnah. For example, after eating, a person may recite the supplication praising Allah for feeding him without any power or ability from himself. This is a simple act, but narrations mention great forgiveness connected to it.

A person goes to the market, eats, sleeps, dresses, enters the home, and leaves the home. In all these ordinary moments, there are Sunnah ways and supplications. If a person learns them, normal life becomes filled with reward. It is as if a person is traveling faster than an airplane in spiritual progress, because every small action becomes worship.

Allah says that if we love Him, we must follow the Prophet *ṣallā Allāhu ‘alayhi wa-sallam*. Through following him, Allah grants His love and forgiveness. What more could a servant want?

Fourth, a person should examine his own faults every day. He should ask, “What mistakes did I make today? What sins did I fall into? What weakness is growing inside me?” Instead of becoming upset when others correct him, he should try to discover his own faults before someone else needs to point them out. This daily self-accounting is a great blessing.

Fifth, a person should keep a regular connection with words of remembrance (*adhkār*). This includes the third kalimah, *subḥān Allāh wa-l-ḥamdu lillāh wa-lā ilāha illā Allāh wa-Allāhu akbar*, seeking forgiveness (*istighfār*), and sending blessings upon the Prophet (*durūd sharīf*). A person may also recite other reliable remembrances taught by the scholars and elders.

When these five things enter daily life—Qur'an recitation, optional prayers, Sunnah practice, self-accounting, and remembrance—the person begins to move forward. He recognizes his mistakes, corrects them, and continues rising. The believer should not stop, and he should not move backward. He should keep walking toward Allah.

A Prayer for Purity and Acceptance

We ask Allah to give us the ability to act upon what is right. May Allah grant us humility (*tawāḍu'*) and protect us from arrogance (*kibr*) and all inward diseases. May He purify our hearts from hypocrisy, our actions from showing off, our tongues from lying, and our eyes from betrayal.

May Allah make faith beloved to us and beautify it in our hearts. May He make disbelief, sin, and disobedience hateful to us. May He give our souls their God-consciousness (*taqwā*) and purify them, for He is the best One to purify them.

May Allah accept the gathering of His servants who came with love for the religion. May He accept the efforts of those who arranged it, those who attended it, and those who wished to attend but could not. May He make such gatherings a means of His pleasure.

May Allah forgive our sins, cover our faults, and not disgrace us in the Hereafter. May He make death easy, the grave easy, crossing the Bridge (*ṣirāṭ*) easy, and entering Paradise easy. We are not capable of standing for a strict accounting, so we ask Him for mercy, pardon, and forgiveness.

May Allah remove heedlessness from our hearts. May He remove the darkness of sins and replace it with light. May He place His love in our hearts after purifying them, because His love belongs in a pure place.

May Allah have mercy on the Muslim community (*ummah*), remove its hardships, protect the oppressed, heal the sick, ease the worries of families, guide the young and old, and protect everyone from trials in religion and worldly life.

May Allah grant us steadfastness upon the religion, protect us from decline, and make us the kind of servants He loves. May He grant us every good that the Prophet *ṣallā Allāhu 'alayhi wa-sallam* asked for, and protect us from every evil from which the Prophet *ṣallā Allāhu 'alayhi wa-sallam* sought protection.

Āmīn.